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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Monday, January 26, 2026

Date	Monday, January 26, 2026
Place	Senate of Virginia, Senate Chamber, State Capitol, Richmond
Length	1h 28m (video)

- Official floor video (Senate of Virginia, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X7VsF7zLkBA
- LIS Senate minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/S

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[00:24:27] This is the Senate of Virginia. Richmond, Virginia. Chamber. This is the Senate of Virginia. Richmond, Virginia.

[00:28:49] The Senate will come to order. The Senators will please take their seats.

[00:29:13] Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The Senators and all in attendance will please stand, if you're able, and we will have a moment of silence. And following the moment of silence, everyone will please remain standing and be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by Nathan Hatfield, Assistant Clerk from the Senate Clerk's Office.

[00:29:49] I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:30:07] The clerk will call the roll. All those present please vote aye. The clerk will close the roll. You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate Journal for Friday, January 23rd, 2026. The senator from Orange moves that the reading of the journal be waived. All in favor of waiving the reading of the journal will record their vote aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all

[00:30:45] the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 35, Noes 3. Ayes 35, Noes 3. The reading of the journal is waived.

[00:31:01] The clerk will report any communications from the House of Delegates. I do not have any Madam President. The clerk will report any communications from the Governor. I do not have any Madam

[00:31:11] President. The chair now recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. My apologies. The chair recognizes this uh senator from chesapeake thank you madam president um madam president i would

[00:31:49] like to request a leave of absence for my seatmate the senator from stafford on pressing personal business the journal will so reflect the clerk will call the calendar senate calendar for monday january 26 2026. uncontested calendar senate bills on third reading now the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Good afternoon, Madam President. Good afternoon. Madam President,

[00:32:24] I move to all the Senate bills on third reading on the uncontested calendar on pages one through two, Senate bills 89 through 186, be placed on their final passage in the block. Any senator desiring move bill from the block shall do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill.

[00:32:40] The question is, shall the Senate bills on the uncontested calendar, third reading pages one through two senate bill 89 through senate bill 186 be placed on their final passage in the block with the understanding that any senator desiring to remove a bill from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the ayes have it the motion is agreed to the bills are before us in the block and the clerk

[00:33:12] will read the number of the bill senate bill 89 senate bill 163 senate bill 186 the question is shall the bills in the block pass that is all are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any

senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll eyes 38 no zero Ayes 38, noes 0, the bills in the block pass.

[00:33:49] Regular calendars, Senate bills on third reading. Senate Bill 6, a bill relating to qualifications of voters' right to vote, persons not entitled to vote. The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Thank you, Madam President. I move the Senate Bill 6 pass in speaking to that.

[00:34:08] The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Senate Bill 6 merely puts before the voters the Constitutional Amendment, Senate Joint Resolution 2. This puts the question on the ballot. I move that the bill pass. The question is, shall Senate Bill 6 pass?

[00:34:26] All in favor of the motion will record their votes, aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their votes? The clerk will close the roll.

[00:34:44] Ayes 21, noes 17. Ayes 21, noes 17, Senate Bill 6 passes. Senate Bill 58, a bill relating to elections, deadline for receipt of absentee ballots and certain other information, 5 o'clock p.m. on the third day after the election.

[00:35:03] The chair recognizes the senator from Arlington. Thank you, Madam President. Good afternoon. Madam President, I move that Senate Bill 58 pass and speaking to that motion. The senator has the floor. Thank you. Senate Bill 58 is a very simple and straightforward bill. It merely changes the time that absentee ballots must be received to be counted. The current law has it. It must be received by noon on the third day after the election. My bill moves that time to 5 p.m.,

[00:35:39] third day after the election so it is straightforward the motivation behind this bill is it it's actually taking the United States Postal Service on average 2.8 days longer to deliver mail than it used to just a few years ago so we're trying to to keep track with reality keep pace with the challenges that our voters might face when they put the ballot in the mail I hope it is the will the body to pass the bill the question is shall senate bill 58 pass all in favor of the motion

[00:36:18] will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll eyes 22 no 16 eyes 22 no 16 senate bill 58 passes senate bill 169 a bill relating to elections candidates for office challenges to candidate qualifications the chair recognizes the senator from western fairfax thank you madam president i move sb 169 pass and speaking to that motion

[00:36:55] the senator has the floor thank you madam president this is a pretty straightforward bill and that creates deadlines for legal challenges to a candidate's uh qualifications so that there's sufficient time to consider these challenges before voting starts and this actually stemmed from a real-life incident in Fairfax County in a school board race where voting had started and somebody decided to bring a challenge to a small administrative issue and it created havoc.

[00:37:28] So this is, again, just for administrative issues. It does not deal with eligibility issues of a candidate. So I move the bill pass. - The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. Speaking to the bill.

[00:37:45] The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Ladies and gentlemen, I saw the vote count on this bill, and I was really mystified that it came out on a partisan basis. Just so we're clear, this

bill, all it says is that if you want to challenge whether somebody's signatures are accurate, whether the notarization of the document's okay, really sort of technical stuff. You've got to do it early.

[00:38:13] You have to do it within so many days of when the signatures are filed, when the paperwork's filed. And in the school board race, there's also been a couple others. There was, I think, a race in Virginia Beach and one somewhere else. But the one in Fairfax, they were like three weeks before the election in October while voting was going on when somebody filed a lawsuit to contest the validity of signatures on petitions that had been filed six months earlier.

[00:38:43] And the judge first found they were invalid, and then he reconsidered in the middle of voting two days later and changed his mind and then went back. I mean, it was crazy for these things to being debated while voting was going on in the middle of an election, instead of these issues being sorted out early.

[00:38:59] And this isn't going to affect anybody based on their party. It could affect the Democrat, Republican equally. The idea is that somebody's got a problem with the technical pieces of your filing, not your residence, not whether you live in the right place, or something that's more fundamentally constitutional, that's in the Constitution.

[00:39:16] But just whether the signatures are right or the notarization's right, you got to do within a reasonable period of time after they're filed and it just allows for the orderly procession of the election so I don't know how this became partisan it shouldn't be and I would hope we could pass this with a healthy but healthy bipartisan vote because it just makes the elections run a lot better and it makes people put out these little technical problems a lot earlier instead of really late in the process the chair recognizes the senator from Lynchburg thank you madam president speaking briefly to the bill the senator has the

[00:39:53] floor and addressing the comments from the senator from Eastern Fairfax I would suggest that the bigger issue is the 45 days of early voting if we didn't have 45 days of early voting these challenges could be brought and voting would not have already begun the question is shall Senate bill 169 pass all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to

[00:40:28] change their vote the clerk will close the roll as 22 no 16 eyes 22 no 16 Senate bill 169 passes Senate bill 449 a bill relating to fundamental right to reproductive freedom the chair recognizes the senator from northern Fairfax thank you madam president I move the bill pass and speaking to the bill. The senator has the floor. Thank you madam president. This is the ballot language that is associated with SJ1 that was passed through this body

[00:41:02] earlier in the session and I renew my motion that we pass the bill. The question is shall Senate bill 449 pass? All in favor of the motion will record their votes aye. Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 21, noes 17. Ayes 21, noes 17. Senate Bill 449 passes. Uncontested calendar. Senate

[00:41:38] bills on second reading. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Madam President, I move that all the Senate bills on second reading on the uncontested calendar on pages 4 through 10, Senate bills 37 through 492 be advanced there engrossment in third reading in a block after the adoption of any amendments thereto. Any senators that are removed bill from the block should do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill.

[00:41:59] The question is, shall all the Senate bills on second reading on the uncontested calendar on pages 4 through 10, Senate Bill 37 through Senate Bill 492, be engrossed in advance to their third reading in the block after the adoption of the amendments thereto, that any senator desiring to remove a bill from the block will do so after the clerk has read the number of the bill.

[00:42:26] All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The clerk will read the number of the bills. Senate Bill 37, reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice with amendments.

[00:42:42] The chair recognizes the senator from Arlington. I move that the amendment be agreed to. The question is, shall the amendment from the Committee for Courts of Justice be agreed to?

[00:42:58] All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The amendment from the Committee of Courts of Justice is agreed to. Senate Bill 70, reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice with a substitute. The Chair recognizes the Senator from Arlington.

[00:43:16] President, Madam President, I move that the substitute be agreed to. The question is, shall the substitute from the Committee for Courts of Justice be agreed to? All in favor of the motion will say aye.

[00:43:31] Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. substitute from the Committee for Courts of Justice is agreed to. Senate Bill 91 reported from the Committee on Education and Health. Senate Bill 97 reported from the Committee on Education and Health with a substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from Western Prince William. Thank you madam president. Madam President I move the committee substitute be agreed to. The question is shall the committee substitute from the Committee on Education and Health be agreed to. All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes

[00:44:08] have it. The committee substitute is agreed to. Senate Bill 105 reported from the Committee on Education and Health. Senate Bill 106 reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice with the substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from Franklin. Thank you, Madam President. Good morning to you. I now move that the committee substitute be agreed to for Senate Bill 106. The question is, shall the committee substitute from the Committee for Courts of Justice be agreed to? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it.

[00:44:43] The committee substitute is agreed to. Senate bill 108 reported from the Committee on Education and Health. Senate bill 117 reported from the Committee on Education and Health. Senate bill 151 reported from the Committee on Education and Health. Senate bill 171 reported from the committee on education and health with a substitute the chair recognizes the senator from Arlington thank you madam president I move that the substitute be agreed to the question is shall the substitute from the committee on education and health be agreed to all in favor of the motion will say aye any

[00:45:21] opposed no the ayes have it the committee substitute is agreed to Senate bill 177 reported from the committee on general laws and technology Senate bill 206 reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice Senate bill 216 reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice Senate bill 242 reported from the Committee on Education and Health Senate bill 291 reported from the Committee on Education and Health with amendment the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Henrico thank you madam chair I move the committee amendment the

[00:46:00] question is shall the committee amendment from the Committee on Education and health be agreed to. All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The committee

amendment is agreed to. Senate bill 293 reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology. Senate bill 318 reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology with a substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from Alexandria. Thank you madam president. I move the committee substitute be agreed to? The question is, shall the committee substitute

[00:46:36] from the Committee on General Laws and Technology be agreed to? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The committee substitute is agreed to. Senate Bill 360 reported from the Committee for Courts of Justice.

[00:46:53] Senate Bill 492 reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology. The question is, shall the Senate bills be engrossed and advanced to their third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no.

[00:47:10] The ayes have it. The bills are engrossed and advanced to their third reading. Regular calendar, Senate bills on second reading. Senate Bill 19, a bill relating to Department of Education, policies relating to instructional material that contains sexually explicit content, applicability, construction.

[00:47:31] Reported from the committee on education and health. The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Thank you madam president I move the Senate bill 19 be engrossed in advance to his third reading The question is shall Senate bill 19 be engrossed in advance to his third reading all in favor of the motion We'll say aye any opposed no the ayes have it Senate bill 19 is engrossed and advanced

[00:48:00] Senate Bill 39, a bill to direct the Department of Education to identify best practices relating to implementing technology tools to assist with identifying students at risk of engaging in self-harm or intending to inflict harm on others.

[00:48:17] Reported from the Committee on Education and Health with amendments. The chair recognizes the senator from Arlington. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the amendment be agreed to. The question is, shall the amendment from the Committee on Education and Health be agreed to?

[00:48:35] All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The committee amendment is agreed to. The senator from Arlington. Madam President, I move that the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 39 be engrossed in advance to its third reading?

[00:48:55] all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the ayes have it Senate bill 39 is engrossed and advanced Senate bill 53 a bill relating to glided vehicle headlights lawful stop by law enforcement officer reported from the committee for courts of justice the chair recognizes the senator from York thank you madam president I move that the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 53 be engrossed in advance to his third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The

[00:49:34] ayes have it. Senate Bill 53 is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 71, a bill relating to Health Care Decisions Act, patients incapable of informed decisions, absence of next of kin, reported from the Committee on Education and Health with amendment the chair recognizes the senator from Arlington thank you madam president madam president I move that the amendment be agreed to the question is shall the committee amendment reported from the committee on education and health be agreed to all in

favor of the motion will say aye aye any opposed no the eyes have it the committee amendment is agreed to the senator from

[00:50:12] Arlington madam president I move that the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 71 be engrossed in advance to his third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The Senate Bill 71 is engrossed in advance. Senate Bill 109, a bill relating to school board policies, parental notification, safe storage of prescription drugs and firearms in household, reported from the Committee on education and health the chair recognizes the senator from Western

[00:50:48] Fairfax madam president I move the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading the question is shall Senate bill 109 be engrossed in advance to his third reading all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the ayes have it SB 109 is engrossed and advanced Senate bill 155 a bill relating to official emblems and designations state native pollinator brown belted bumblebee reported from the committee on general laws and technology the chair recognizes

[00:51:22] the senator from Lynchburg thank you madam president I rise to move that this very important bill designating the brown belted bumblebee as the native state pollinator please be engrossed in advance to its next constitutional reading you've created quite a buzz with your bill senator the question is the question is shall Senate bill 155 be engrossed in advance to his third

[00:51:59] reading all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the ayes have it Senate bill 155 is engrossed and advanced. Senate bill 227 a bill relating to arbitration high-volume arbitration service providers selection of arbitrator civil penalty reported from the committee for courts of justice with the substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Madam.

[00:52:35] Move the bill be engrossed and advanced his third reading. Senator. Move the amendment. The substitute. Move the substitute. The question is, shall the committee substitute from the Committee for Courts of Justice be agreed to?

[00:52:53] All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The committee substitute is agreed to. Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Move the bill to be engrossed and advanced to his third reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 227 be engrossed and advanced?

[00:53:08] All in favor will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The bill is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 258, a bill relating to Virginia Human Rights Act, menopause or paramenopause discrimination prohibited, reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology.

[00:53:29] The chair recognizes the senator from Western Fairfax. I move the bill be engrossed and advanced to its third constitutional reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 258 be engrossed and advanced to its third reading? All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Any opposed, no.

[00:53:46] The ayes have it. The bill is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 315, a bill relating to Safeguarding American Veteran Empowerment Act, Prohibited Practices, Penalties, reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology. The chair recognizes the senator from Alexandria.

[00:54:05] Thank you, Madam President. I move the bill be engrossed and passed to its third constitutional reading. The question is: Shall Senate Bill 315 be engrossed in advance to his third reading? All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Any opposed, no.

[00:54:21] The ayes have it. The bill is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 330: A bill relating to Virginia Criminal Sentencing Commission, Department of Corrections, Probation and Parole Officers, Subscriber Agreements with Clerk's Offices, Secure Remote Access to Court Records, Reported from Committee for Courts of Justice.

[00:54:42] chair recognizes the senior senator from loudon thank you madam president my president I move the bill engrossed and advanced third constitutional reading the question is shall Senate bill 330 be engrossed and advanced to his third reading all in favor of the motion will say aye any opposed no the bill is engrossed and advanced Senate bill 337 a bill relating to Virginia National Guard other state militia certain communications prohibited reported from the committee on general laws and technology the chair recognizes the senior senator from loudon thank you madam president madam president i move the bill be engrossed in advance to its third

[00:55:18] constitutional reading the question is shall senate bill 337 be engrossed in advance to its third constitutional reading all in favor of the motion we'll say aye any opposed no the ayes have it the bill is engrossed and advanced senate bill 459 a bill relating to virginia consumer protection act liquefied petroleum gas fitters service disconnection requirements civil penalties reported from the committee on general laws and technology the chair recognizes the senator from king george thank you madam president i move the bill be engrossed in advance to its third reading

[00:55:56] the question is shall senate bill 459 be engrossed in advance to his third reading all in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The bill is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 575, a bill relating to Virginia Public Procurement Act Joint and Cooperative Procurement Construction Exception reported from the Committee on General Laws and Technology with the substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from Orange. Thank you, Madam President. I now move the committee substitute be agreed to. The question is, shall the committee substitute from the Committee on General Laws and Technology be agreed to. All in favor of

[00:56:35] the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The committee substitute is agreed to. Senator from Orange. Thank you Madam President. I now move the bill be engrossed and advanced to its third constitutional reading. The question is, shall Senate Bill 575 be engrossed and advanced to its third reading? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The bill is engrossed and advanced. Senate Bill 769, a bill relating to the General Appropriation Act Department of Elections reported from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations with the substitute. The chair recognizes the senator from

[00:57:15] Portsmouth. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the committee substitute from Senate Finance and Appropriations be agreed to. The question is, shall the substitute from the Committee on Finance and Appropriations be agreed to? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed no the committee substitute is agreed to senator from portsmouth thank you madam president madam president i now move that the bill be engrossed and advanced to his third constitutionally required reading the question is shall senate bill 769 be engrossed and advanced to his third reading all in favor of the motion we'll say aye any opposed no the ayes have it the bill is

[00:57:54] engrossed and advanced uncontested calendars senate bills on first reading the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Henrico, I'm sorry, Eastern Fairfax. I moved you. Never been called that before. Thank you, Madam President. I moved on all the Senate bills on first reading on the

uncontested regular calendars, pages 15 through 20, Senate Bill 75 through 538. The rules be suspended in the first constitutional reading the titles be dispensed with. The question

[00:58:30] is, shall the rules be suspended in the first constitutional reading of the titles of the Senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars pages 15 through 20 Senate bill 75 through Senate bill 538 be dispensed with all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll as 38 no zero eyes 38 no zero the reading of the

[00:59:06] titles is dispensed with. The chair recognizes the senator who has moved to Eastern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I move those bills go by for the day before I move again. The question is, shall the Senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars now on their second reading be passed by for the day? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The ayes have it.

[00:59:37] the bills will go by for the day the chair calls on the senator from eastern Fairfax the inquiry of the clerk does that complete today's snowy icy Monday calendar yes sir excellent thanks is there any other business to come before the Senate yes madam president the chair recognizes the senator from Lynchburg madam president I request that we return to the morning hour

[01:00:13] briefly we will now return to the morning hour thank you madam president I rise to ask that the record reflect that my seatmate, the Honorable Senator from Bonetat, is away on pressing personal business.

[01:00:30] Thank you, Senator. The journal will so reflect. The chair recognizes the Senator from Northern Fairfax. Madam President, I'll just rise for a quick introduction, I mean announcement, excuse me.

[01:00:46] The Senator has the floor. Thank you. In the resolutions, we will have SR 18, the Commending the Walk for Peace. You might have seen on social media that there is a group of 19 Buddhist monks who are walking from Fort Worth, Texas to Washington, DC.

[01:01:02] They are scheduled to be here on Sunday, February the 1st. I would encourage anybody who can be here to join, to welcome them. But I'm hoping that everybody in the body would sign their commending resolution that I'll be presenting to them when they arrive.

[01:01:23] Thank you, Senator. The Chair recognizes the Senator from Rockingham. Madam President, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. Madam President, I'll make this brief. We've been talking about the Virginia Clean Economy Act for a couple of years now, and have been talking about the potential that it is causing serious problems with the grid, and that there will be consequences that are going to impose significant hardships on the people of the Commonwealth of Virginia. Well, yesterday, at least in my

[01:02:00] region and the senator from Shenandoah County's region, we received a very unsettling message from the major electric power generator and supplier for our region. We were notified that PJM had directed them that if the The usage of power did not drop dramatically, that there was a very real possibility that

[01:02:33] power was going to be cut off in Shenandoah County, Page County, Frederick County, and the city of Winchester. There are people who are very concerned and very afraid that their power is going to

be cut off.

[01:02:50] don't take showers even because of the electricity that is being used. This is not just a theoretical issue. This is a very serious policy issue that we're going to have to address sooner or later. We have people who are suffering as a consequence of, you know, the fear and the concern. We just don't have enough generation power in Virginia and it's self-inflicted by the Virginia clean economy act and this warning is not lifted now the snowstorms over because

[01:03:26] of the exceedingly cold temperatures they've been told that this warning is in effect for the entirety of this week I respectfully submit that we need to do something sooner and not wait until we start reading newspaper articles like in northern Europe in which people are freezing to death in their own homes so So it would be my hope that at some point in the very near future, we're going to revisit the serious restrictions that are imposed by the Virginia Clean Economy Act on our ability to generate power in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[01:03:59] Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Alexandria. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Madam President, I am deeply troubled by events that are unfolding far from our Commonwealth, that the strike at the heart of this nation's core values of human dignity, protection of children, and respect for due process. Last week in Columbia Heights, Minnesota, a five-year-old child, five-year-old, named Liam Ramos was taken into federal custody along with his father as

[01:04:34] they arrived home from Liam's preschool. According to school officials, the child was removed from a still-running vehicle in his own driveway. In what local authorities have described as a deeply disturbing tactic, Liam was asked by the agents to knock on his own front door to determine if anyone else was inside. Another adult at the scene offered to care for the child, but the request was denied. Both Liam and his father, according to local officials, have an active asylum case with no deportation orders, were transported to a detention facility in Texas. And whether or not

[01:05:11] we agree or disagree with the country's immigration laws, I hope we would agree that nobody, especially a five-year-old child, should be placed at the center of such enforcement actions. Children should not be removed suddenly from homes, families, schools, and communities, and then held far from all that is familiar. The image of a preschooler caught up in national enforcement tactics has galvanized parents, educators, and community leaders. It has raised profound moral questions about the human cost of the policy choices we make as legislators and our responsibility to ensure that policies enacted must follow

[01:05:50] due process and hold human rights in the highest regard. Liam's story is compounded when we look at other recent events in the Minneapolis area. Federal immigration enforcement operations are responsible for the deaths of two American citizens. Renee Good and Alex Priddy were fatally shot during encounters with fatal federal agents as part of a heightened immigration enforcement surge. These killings have caused deep anguish not just in the community of Minnesota but across this country. Families, local leaders, and civil rights advocates are demanding transparent and independent investigations

[01:06:29] into the circumstances that led to these tragic loss of lives. Government power must be balanced with compassion, restraint, and accountability. These events prompt serious and sober reflection on how enforcement actions are conducted and how force is used. We do not have to agree on both sides

of the aisle to agree that on every policy on both sides of the aisle to agree the children and all the vulnerable among us deserve protection. All Americans deserve transparent justice when deadly force is used. I respectfully urge this

[01:07:06] body and leaders across the country to reaffirm our commitment to humane and accountable governance. Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the Senator from Western West Prince William County. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, rise for a point of personal privilege. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I heard earlier that we have a self-inflicted issue regarding our energy and that we need to do something now regarding that i agree but it's not because of the virginia clean economy act

[01:07:39] it's because data center demand for energy is stressing our grid unlike anything virginia has ever seen we recently saw a report that said that it was contributing to it in virginia an 833 increase where i'll just read it to you right here it says ai data center power demand in Virginia has contributed to an 833 percent increase in the 2024 PGM auction prices for the 2025-2026 market and it's estimated to drive up the Commonwealth's energy ban by 183 percent in 2040. Meanwhile, Madam President, some

[01:08:19] of us have been introducing legislation to deal with the problem for years now and when we had a very simple bill regarding demand response to deal with this, I can't help but notice who voted for it and who voted against it. And then we got the bill, even though we did earn bipartisan support, at least down the hall, and the bill got vetoed last year. Got you better than that, right? So now we have a whole lot of bills that are being introduced on this very topic this year. And which means, Madam President, based on the comments I heard,

[01:08:54] I am so excited for the upcoming strong bipartisan support we're going to have as these bills come in to commerce and labor, as these bills come into general laws, local government and all the rest of our fine committees so that we can do something about the power surge that is not only coming from the data center industry as they are not just taking up so much energy and water and land and all these other resources but at the same time we know that they disproportionately more so than any other consumer of energy anywhere in Virginia are causing the very stress on the grid

[01:09:33] that we heard about earlier thank you madam president thank you senator the chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax thank you madam president point of personal privilege the senator has the floor thank you madam president I appreciate that the senator from Western Fairfax is point there what we can talk about on the demand side oh sorry sorry western prince william i just moved her too yeah fairfax isn't that bad come on it's not that gross um but i appreciate the points that she raises about what we can do on the demand side i would like to point out that the commission on

[01:10:09] electrical utility regulation made several proposals including one on demand response um which we're going to look take a very comprehensive look at the data center demand response over the next year and other measures we can use to reduce data center demand i think we We actually proposed, I think, about three or four bills on that, which are pending and in front of us that we look for bipartisan support on.

[01:10:30] I also just want to note a couple other things. There was a report that came out recently by, I can't remember the outfit, it was a university in California, I believe, but is a well-respected university when it comes to energy demand.

[01:10:45] And they pointed out that in Virginia, our demand, or sorry, our rising costs are driven by a couple things. one is um inflation we've seen over the last couple years and you know the way we do rates it takes a little bit of time for the cost to catch up with rates because of the way the rate process works it said the second reason that rates were up was because of the war in ukraine and the strains that's putting on the natural gas supply and it's running at the price of gas and um uh and i would note that um it'd be nice if our current administration would actually do

[01:11:23] something to solve that war instead of it seems like prolong it. And in that vein, I would note that gas prices, because gas prices, and a big chunk of our electricity is generated by gas, gas prices are going to continue to cause pressure on our energy prices. One of the things we could do to mitigate that risk to our taxpayers for decades would be to use carbon-free sources to produce electricity and one of the best ways to do that would be to do wind and

[01:11:59] one of the things that that report that's mentioned said was one of the reasons that the VCEA had caused some increase in prices temporarily the report said temporarily was because we were funding the cost of the wind project offshore in Virginia Beach and that we hadn't been able to turn it on yet and guess what But there's a guy in a house across the river from me who has something about wind who tried to shut down our wind project, our $11 billion wind project, which is actually a huge priority

[01:12:36] to Hampton Roads, which we're trying to turn into a wind hub to generate lots of jobs. But I just want to note that as soon as we turn that project on, it is going to save us 200 Virginians and businesses $278 million a year in fuel costs per year.

[01:12:53] So that's $2 billion, $2.7 billion at least a decade, especially if gas prices keep going up. And it'll also generate $57 million a year in renewable energy certificates that we can sell.

[01:13:11] So $3 billion a decade Virginians could sell if the man across the river would just let us finish our little wind project. And you know what? Generate some electricity to deal with the demand that is causing this concern.

[01:13:26] The other thing I'd point out is in the Commission on Electrical Utility Regulation in May, we heard a presentation about a bill that came out of Congress that I haven't heard anybody talk about a whole lot favorably yet. We like to call it H.R.1. Other people like to describe it as big and beautiful. The presentation we heard was that the policies in the bill are going to result in reduction in solar construction of 125 gigawatts nationally. It's going to result in a reduction

[01:14:02] in energy infrastructure investment of $220 billion nationwide because of the cuts in tax credits to renewable energy programs. It's going to cost America 292,000 jobs, all because somebody across the river doesn't like energy that isn't reliant on natural gas, which, by the way, I don't have a big problem with, but he's very focused on energy from natural gas, which is subject to wars running up its price, creating these kinds of problems.

[01:14:40] And so, like the senator from Western Prince William, I look forward to all the bipartisan support we're going to get to reduce the energy costs of Virginians when we construct a lot of solar and wind and storage and invest and build it here in the Commonwealth of Virginia where we can generate energy in Virginia, generate jobs in Virginia, and keep our money here in Virginia instead of sending it to other states and abroad.

[01:15:09] I look forward to all that bipartisan support. Thank you, Madam President. Thank you, Senator. The chair recognizes the senator from Hanover. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for point of personal privilege. The senator has the floor. Madam President, it seems that today's weather has resulted in all of us being somewhat loquacious on the floor.

[01:15:31] But some of these comments, I think, need to be addressed. As I look out today, and my daughter's out of school, and many of us had difficult travels to get here to the Capitol, but we're all still working. Madam President, as I look out today though, the one thing that's not working in Virginia is solar panels, because they're all covered with sleet and ice.

[01:15:55] And Madam President, as we talk about energy, it is important to have this conversation. But as some people on the floor have articulated, we have based Virginians energy policies on things that some people in this legislature have decided are important and that's wind and solar we've not based it on what is the most fair for Virginians or the most cost effective for Virginians that can be our focus and if the senators who are articulating that we should focus more on wind and solar want it to be the most

[01:16:33] affordable for Virginians, then I'm going to give them an opportunity. I have a bill that says the State Corporation Commission should only focus on what is fair and affordable for Virginians. Take out what our personal feelings are. If I personally feel natural gas is reliable and is working today and is working at peak capacity today, where solar is not, you know, let the state corporation commission make the determination whether that fair and affordable energy is the

[01:17:07] best way to go if the state corporation commission feels that putting additional government money to making sure that solar projects are cost less so you spend taxpayer dollars to make it cost less for ratepayers i don't think that that's affordable but if the commission does we can have that conversation. Madam President, we can have fair and affordable energy if we take our directives out saying that we have to pick one of the other. And Madam President, I would definitely have a

[01:17:43] conversation as well about the Clean Economy Act. And as you look at some of the power that is being generated today, some of that is breaking the rules that we've all established. Breaking the rules that we've established for the environment because we made the determination that making sure you can get energy today is more important than following those rules.

[01:18:09] And Madam President, there are bills moving through this legislature that some communities are saying it's more important that I have the energy in my area than complying with the Virginia Clean Economy Act. Let's make that the rule for all Virginians, not just part of Virginia.

[01:18:28] Fair and reasonable prices should be our directive, not our personal feelings about which way to go is better. Let's have that debate. Let's make it straightforward. Let's not pick winners and losers. Let's base it on objective, fair, and actually affordable for Virginia.

[01:18:49] Thank you, Senator. Seeing no further senators wishing to speak, the clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Announcements for today, Monday, January 26, 2026.

[01:19:06] Committee on Commerce and Labor will meet 15 minutes after adjournment in Senate Room A, GAB. The Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Economic Development and Natural Resources will not meet. The Northern Virginia Delegation Caucus will meet at 5:00 p.m. in House Room 1 of the Capitol.

[01:19:25] Tomorrow, Tuesday, January 27, 2026. The Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on General Government will meet at 7:30 a.m. in the Senate Finance and Appropriations Room, 13th Floor, GAB. The Agriculture, Conservation and Natural Resources Subcommittee on Water Usage will meet at 8:00 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB.

[01:19:48] The Committee on Finance and Appropriations will meet at 9:00 a.m. in Senate Room A, GAB. The Agriculture, Conservation, and Natural Resources Subcommittee on Companion Animals will meet at 9:30 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB.

[01:20:05] The Democratic Caucus will meet at 11:15 a.m. in Senate Room 1 of the Capitol. The Republican Caucus will meet at 11:30 a.m. in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. The Chair recognizes the Senator from Portsmouth.

[01:20:21] Thank you Madam President. Madam President, I move that the Senate do now adjourn until 12 noon on tomorrow. The question is, shall the Senate now adjourn until 12 noon tomorrow? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Any opposed, no. The Senate stands adjourned until 12 noon tomorrow.

[01:20:42] Senators, an update to the announcements. The Northern Virginia Delegation Caucus has been canceled for today.

[01:20:57] today Senate chamber be sure to stay connected with live sessions catch up on past meetings and

[01:24:28] explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel this is the Senate

[01:25:34] of Virginia Richmond Virginia chamber